

3.5.3 Finding and installing the missing codec

There are millions of codecs with varying efficiencies in encoding and compressing multimedia files. However, there are a limited number of popular video codecs and typically, your movie file/CD should be of one of the types in the list below:

MPEG-1 Part 2: One of the most popular, nearly all computers in the world can play this codec. It is regularly used for video CDs (VCDs) and sometime for online video.

MPEG-2 Part 2: Used in most digital video broadcasting, cable distribution and DVD systems. Also used in another form for SVCD. On DVD, it supports widescreen with good picture quality. It's not as good on SVCD, but definitely better than VCD. (Note: SVCD can hold 40 minutes of video on a CD whereas VCD can fit 60-70 minutes.)

MPEG-4 Part 2: Relative to MPEG-2, it offers better quality and is intended for use on the Internet and broadcast and storage media.

MPEG-4 Part 10: The current state of the art in standardised compression technology. It is rapidly gaining adoption in many applications, and has been recently adopted in a number of companies' products including the PlayStation Portable, Nero Digital product suite, and Mac OS X v10.4.

DivX, XviD and 3ivx: Video codec packages using MPEG-4 Part 2, with the *.avi, *.mp4, *.ogm or *.mkv file extension formats.

Sorenson 3: Many movie trailers on the Internet use this codec. It is used by Apple's popular QuickTime movies, which have the .mov file extension.

WMV (Windows Media Video): Microsoft's video codec family includes WMV 7, WMV 8, and WMV 9. It can be used right from low-resolution video for dial-up users to HDTV. Files can be written to CD-Rs and DVD-Rs or output to many types of devices. Also